

LLM environmental impact is more reasonable than commonly believed

Posted by u/rmoduloq • 0 points • 2 comments

I haven't looked up the numbers until this morning, and when I did they really surprised me. (Note: This table was generated by ChatGPT itself.)

Text conversations have a very small impact. It seems fine to talk to LLMs over text all day long without worrying. In fact if you would be doing other online activities instead, talking to the LLM is probably the environmentally friendly choice.

Asking it to generate images is a little more carbon-intensive, but still very reasonable compared to common activities. If you're environmentally conscious you'll want to avoid having it generate images over and over for hours, but if it's a few images here and there, or even every day, that should be fine.

Obviously if you're talking to AI programmatically (writing a program that talks to their API) the environmental impact could be quite high if you're sending over a ton of data / requests. But for regular conversations, especially if they're text-only, the environmental concerns are a lot more reasonable than most people think.

Comments

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🤖

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Prompt (ChatGPT):

How much environmental impact does (1) having a conversation with an LLM, (2) asking an LLM to do image generation, have on the environment? Can you compare it to other common activities (driving a car, going on a plane, barbecuing, getting plastic utensils, etc.)